

CDN Incident Alert: 092. TLP: CLEAR		Date
Title	MD Paid to post: Russia-linked 'digital army' seeks to undermine Moldovan election	25/09/2025

Summary

- At least 253 accounts partaking in coordinated inauthentic behavior (CIB) are associated with a Moscow-linked operation that the [BBC](#) and [Ziarul de Gardă](#) (ZdG) covertly infiltrated.
- The network showed great versatility and made at least 27,704 posts, 44 percent of which emerged in the summer of 2025.
- The payments were reportedly issued through PromSvyazBank (PSB), a Russian bank under international sanctions also used by Russia's Ministry of Defense (MoD).
- The narratives targeted Maia Sandu, PAS, and the EU. The operation shared calls to protest and tailored polls, in an apparent attempt to establish a foundation to claim a PAS defeat. The group also promoted pro-Moldova Mare, pro-Victoria Furtuna, and pro-Evghenia Gutul content.
- The operation reached 55 million views, 2,207,894 likes, 295,608 shares, and 239,016 comments across three platforms (Facebook, TikTok, Instagram).
- Recommendations include preserving evidence and notifying relevant Moldovan authorities.

Incident

A reportedly Russia-linked network recruited and trained hundreds of social media "activists," known as "InfoLeaders" within the operation. These individuals posted coordinated inauthentic content across TikTok, Facebook, and Instagram. The operation, initially aligned with the Shor-affiliated Victory Bloc and later pivoting to promote the Moldova Mare party, paid participants and directed their activity through "curators" using Telegram bots, content kits, and performance monitoring. Messaging primarily targeted President Sandu and her ruling PAS party, accusing them of corruption, alleging Western interference, and claiming the betrayal of national interests, while promoting opposition figures and pro-Russia narratives. The effort aimed to influence Moldovan voters ahead of the September 2025 parliamentary election, with BBC and ZdG reporting that financial transfers and coordination could be traced back to Russia.

Systemic violation assessment:

The operation could harm democratic processes and elections, as the network promoted fake polls, reportedly to be leveraged in the event of a PAS victory to claim voter manipulation. The content was tailored to fit pre-established narratives curated by the Telegram group curators. It focused on defaming Sandu and PAS, while accusing the EU and France of intervening in sovereign elections and questioning the integrity of judiciary processes against politicians convicted of fraud. The content was disseminated by inauthentic personas and trained operatives, who amplified narratives on-demand. The network consisted entirely of accounts partaking in CIB. The content dissemination violates multiple Terms of Service (ToS) clauses of the platforms, and the payments were reportedly issued through PromSvyazBank (PSB), a Russian bank that is also used by Russia's MoD.

Narrative -

Meta narrative: Western leverage and domestic capture erode Moldova's sovereignty

Sub-narratives: Maia Sandu is a puppet of the West; the West/EU want to impose a pro-LGBTQ+ agenda; PAS is going to lose the elections; PAS destroyed the country; Romania/France/the EU are interfering in the Moldovan electoral process; Moldova will be dragged into war.

Impact

Reach: 55,367,950 views, 2,207,894 likes, 295,608 shares, and 239,016 comments on Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok combined.

Outcome: TBD

Key Objectives and Behaviours

Objective: [T0066 – Degrade Adversary](#) – PAS and Sandu-adjacent defamatory content

Objective: : [T0139.00 – Discourage](#) – Undermine confidence in Moldova's elections by sharing curated polls established by third-party actors.

[T0049.001 – Trolls amplify and manipulate](#) – InfoLeader is a content farm that paid individuals to establish accounts, and produce content on-demand to meet domestic and political developments with tailored narratives

T0015 – Create hashtags and search artifacts – Launched more than 20,000 hashtags to lead microtargeted campaigns

Recommendations and Actions Taken:

Actions Taken: TikTok and Facebook have already deplatformed parts of the network.

Recommendations:

- Preserve evidence and archive post data;
- Notify Moldovan authorities and Central Election Commission;
- Notify EU mission to Moldova.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	<u>FIMI Assessment</u>
TBC	Russia, Shor-supported parties, NGO Evrazia	BBC: https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/c4g5kl0n5d2o			
		ZdG: https://www.zdg.md/en/kremlins-digital-army-an-undercover-investigation-its-paid-let-me-tell-you-its-paid-directly-from-moscow/			
		ZdG: https://www.zdg.md/en/video-kremlins-digital-army-ii-crypto-salaries-the-comrade-and-the-enemy-a-zdg-undercover-investigation/	Victoria Olari, Valentin Chatelet, DFRLab	TikTok, Facebook, Instagram	E.g. Low certainty Medium certainty High certainty

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